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Who Moved the Stone?

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Who Moved the Stone?

Today's Reading: John 20:1-5

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Now on the first day of the week Mary Magdalene came to the tomb early, while it was still dark, and saw that the stone had been taken away from the tomb."

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Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb early on Sunday morning. It was the first day of the week. Soon thereafter, Jesus' followers started worshiping him on this day. It was to honor the day of his resurrection from the dead.

That Christ is worshiped on Sunday is another proof he was raised from the dead. Think about it. For more than a millennium, Jews had faithfully worshiped God on Saturday. Yet in a brief period of time, Christians changed this sacred worship day. Plus, they worshiped Jesus on this day. There is one major reason: They had seen him alive. It was a way to honor the importance of the resurrection.

The resurrection proves not only that Jesus is God, but that he is also worthy of worship.

The other Gospel accounts share that Mary Magdalene was not alone at the tomb. There were other women with her. You always want to make sure you read these accounts alongside one another so you will have the most complete picture of what happened. Good detectives always talk to multiple witnesses so they can put together the full story of what happened. Their gathering of independent accounts can help prove there was no corroboration.

When the women arrived, they saw that the large stone that had been placed in front of the tomb had been rolled away. And they couldn't find Jesus' body.

Mary Magdalene pondered a very significant question: Who moved the stone? It's a question of great importance. Your answer determines your eternal destination.

Not knowing what had happened, Mary Magdalene concluded the Roman authorities had moved the stone. That's one option. But why would they? They were clearly instructed by Pilate to guard the tomb and make sure no one moved the

stone and stole Jesus' body. Plus, if the body had been stolen, they would have to suffer the penalty of the person whose body was gone. That means they would have been crucified themselves. They were highly motivated to keep Jesus' body in the tomb.

Others since have suggested the Jewish authorities had moved the stone and stolen the body. But the question asked about the Roman authorities must similarly be asked here: Why would they? They wanted all resurrection rumors squelched. They had nothing to gain by stealing Jesus' body.

Still others say the disciples rolled away the stone and stole Jesus' body. But was this possible? How could a ragtag group of forlorn, discouraged men elude crack Roman guards, move the huge stone, and steal the body? It makes no rational sense. Also, they were hiding for their lives. They thought persecution and death would come to them as it had for their Master. Why would they make themselves readily available to potential arrest and crucifixion?

There is really only one remaining option for who moved the stone: God did. And he moved the stone not to let Jesus out, but to let you in. He wanted everyone, for all time, to see that the tomb was empty.

Jesus was no longer there. The tomb was empty. He is alive!

And now you know this good news: Because of Jesus' resurrection, when you place your faith in him, your sins are forever forgiven.

Your heart can rest in this hope—today and every day you will ever face.

[from "Hearing the Voice of God" by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]